



like. If we are not eliminating removable injustices, then we are living without justice in a more practical sense. This can be said about many countries, particularly India. There are two things to say here. One is that institutions don't sell or guarantee justice since it also depends on our behavioural patterns and our interactions with each other. So we shouldn't put the blame only on the institutional weakness. For example, there are many injustices that could be removed within the democratic system in India that have not been removed, such as elimination of caste divisions and institutionally we can still do further. But there are also human behavioural failures connected with the practice that have been very difficult to eliminate in India no matter how much our theories of the rationality of the caste system have been revised.

Our biggest strength is in having a democratic system, having a basically tolerant people, having a population that likes arguments and doesn't mind disagreement, that tolerates eccentric views, that is willing to engage in debates, and that finds free public media to be acceptable and very important in their lives. Newspapers may be shrinking in the rest of the world, but in India they have been growing. These are very positive factors. I think the weaknesses lie in the fact that the newspapers have to be more probing and have to go more into less immediately visible injustices. Injustice of talent is immediately visible and has been dealt with but not the injustice of continuing hunger. We need more vigorous practices, more public engagement on these issues and also, to some extent, we have to be less engaged with the past. In my judgement, I don't want to be ostracising the Left—I am very much a part of the Left—but I'm disappointed that, to some extent, the Left intelligentsia has been imprisoned by the past, the Cold War. America may be a threat in many ways but I don't see it as the biggest threat to India or to the rest of the world. One has to rethink that. My hero is public reasoning and I would like everyone—both on the Left and Right—to engage more with it. People have to read each other a bit more, argue with each other a bit more. And we have the tradition and liberty to do it. It's a question of practising it with a greater determination.

Since Montesquieu, it has been argued that the market will keep people away from harm-

ful activities, that is, if you engage in the market, you will not go around blowing other people up. This was an idea discussed by Albert O. Hirschman in his book *The Passions and the Interests: Political Arguments for Capitalism Before Its Triumph*. And it's an argument that is still being used by authors like Thomas Friedman: because of the paucity of jobs in the economy, there is an easy recruitment of fundamentalists and violent extremists. Another

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argument is that it generates efficiency but not necessarily equity. And that was one of Adam Smith's arguments in *Wealth of Nations*. He considered markets to be in need of support from other institutions. Many people would like to think that markets generate happiness, though I don't think it is a part of the intellectual history of the market.

Singapore attempted a multiracial society and it has been a success. No other society has been so successful in terms of multiracial, multi-ethnic, multicultural integration as Singapore has been without people merging into a melting pot. They really practice multiple identities. There are things to learn from Singapore even though it is not a democratic country in the Indian sense. As democracy is concerned, I think, moving to a dictatorial system is not going to help matters but practicing democracy more vigorously is important.

This article is based on Amartya Sen's conversation with S. Prasannarajan

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I want an India where the poorest child has access to decent education, health care nutrition and shelter.”

N.R. NARAYANA MURTHY
Chairman and
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